SHRI MAHARAJADHIRAJA MAHARAJA OF THE MUGHAL EMPIRE

Brindavan had long been a holy site of pilgrimage associated with the pastoral childhood of Krishna, but it had gained prominence in the sixteenth century when the Chaitanya sect began preaching its message of complete and ecstatic devotion to Krishna. The explosive rise of the Bhakti movement in the region and its proximity to Agra and Fatehpur Sikri meant that the Mughal court was familiar with the sacrality of the place. Akbar, Hamida Banu, Raja Todar Mal, and Raja Birbal had all extended their patronage to temples and priests in Mathura and Brindavan. In a series of farmans issued in the 1590s, Akbar specifically ordered that the Brahmin Vithal Rai, priest of the temple of Govardhan Nath, not be harassed about questions of faith and be allowed to pray for the welfare of the empire as he had always done. Officers were to desist from demanding any form of tax from Vithal Rai and not harm him in any way. Vithal Rai was no ordinary priest: he had a long and illustrious list of disciples including Harkha Bai, Todar Mal, Birbal, Baz Bahadur, Tansen, Man Singh, and, in an earlier time, Rani Durgavati of Gondwana. Despite the emperor's farman, Hamida Banu had to issue further farmans confirming the demands of the emperor since some Mughal officers had ignored the earlier decrees. Hamida Banu's farman was detailed and explicit:

> May it be known that according to the farman of the exalted and the just Emperor, the cows belonging to the indisputable prayer offerer (well wisher) Vithalesharai Brahmin, may graze wherever they are and not a single individual out of the khalis or jagir should molest them or prevent them from grazing. They must permit his cows to graze (wherever they are). The above mentioned (Vithalrai) should therefore remain easy at heart. It is incumbent that they must act according to the order and carry it out.

It would appear that when officials created trouble for the people, they then appealed to royal Mughal women to ensure that the Padshah's farmans were obeyed.